

About the report

The Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry commissioned AUSVET to undertake an independent review of daytime and night-time livestock vessel inspections. The review examined whether inspection timing influences the detection of biosecurity risk material and assessed associated scientific and operational considerations.

The report analyses the current evidence base, identifies key data gaps, including invertebrate detection and detectability under different conditions and finds no definitive evidence that nighttime inspections are less effective than those conducted during the day, while noting that the available evidence remains limited and the consequences of any failure of detection are high.

Australia's biosecurity system remains our highest priority, and maintaining strong, effective protections is fundamental to supporting both industry and the broader national interest. The review points to a cautious, evidence-based approach that does not support immediate implementation of night-time inspections but instead highlights the need to build the evidence base through a controlled, risk-based trial with appropriate safeguards.

The department recognises the operational pressures facing industry and is committed to working collaboratively to design a practical and workable trial that addresses key uncertainties. Future decisions will be guided by the evidence and our shared objective of maintaining strong biosecurity settings, ensuring that any trial focuses on testing safeguards and effectiveness, not lowering standards, and supports both biosecurity and trade.

Download the report

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Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/aircraft-vessels-military/vessels/ausvet-report>